Policy

Exceptional Circumstances

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to support QSPP Program Rules and describe circumstances under which an application for extension or permanent change will be considered for an assessment date, a corrective action due date to address a minor non-conformance, or an accreditation expiry date.

Scope

Any application for reschedule, extension or permanent date change must be made prior to the corrective action due date or accreditation expiry date. All pharmacies should be ready to be assessed under the program at any point, and therefore variations to the confirmed assessment date can only be granted in exceptional circumstances.

Exceptional circumstances are considered to be unavoidable or unforeseen events that have an immediate impact in the pharmacy's ability to deliver regular services and where the pharmacy has done all reasonable action to mitigate impact to maintain their accreditation (out of the pharmacy's control).

Examples of exceptional circumstances may include, but are not limited to:

- recent burglary or severe unexpected damage to premises, e.g. fire, flood
- bereavement of immediate family member
- unforeseen significant medical emergencies
- natural disasters.

Consideration may also be provided where the pharmacy is moving location or a sale of a pharmacy, depending on impact to business operations.

Reasonable requests for additional time which are not considered exceptional circumstances will be considered based on resources available at the time.

All applications should include the provision of detailed information and evidence to support the request.

Accreditation expiry date extension and assessment date reschedule requests

A pharmacy may request an accreditation expiry date extension of no more than three calendar months. This request must be received prior to the pharmacy's existing accreditation expiry date. The request will only be granted in exceptional circumstances.

A pharmacy may also request an assessment date reschedule in instances where moving the assessment date will not impact the pharmacy from completing all assessment activities prior to the accreditation expiry date. As with extension requests, these requests will only be granted in exceptional circumstances.

Scenario	Result
Change requested due to exceptional circumstances	Assessment rebooked without charge.
Change requested due to reasons outside pharmacy's control, but which are not exceptional circumstances	Assessment may be rebooked, subject to QSPP operational requirements, including assessor availability.
Change requested due to pharmacy not being ready for assessment	Assessment unable to be rebooked. Cancellation policy may apply.

Corrective action extension

A pharmacy has 30 days from the interim report to remediate any corrective actions. A pharmacy may request a corrective action extension of no more than one month (to a maximum of two months from the interim report date) to allow more time to address minor non-conformances identified during the QSPP Assessment.

Due to the higher risk associated with major non-conformances there is no facility to apply for extension.

Requests for extensions will be considered as follows:

Scenario	Result
Extension requested due to exceptional circumstances	Extension will be granted.
Extension requested due to reasonable reasons outside pharmacy's control, but which are not exceptional circumstances	Extension may be granted, provided pharmacy demonstrates ongoing attempts to resolve issue.
Extension requested where exceptional circumstances do not apply, and the pharmacy has not made reasonably attempts to resolve issue prior to request	Extension will not be granted.

In instances where a pharmacy is undergoing the Corrective Action Review Request process, an extension may be applied at the sole discretion of QSPP to accommodate this.

Permanent accreditation expiry date change

Where a pharmacy has identified that their accreditation expiry date is consistently problematic for them to accommodate the QSPP assessment they can apply for a permanent accreditation expiry date change. QSPP will consider these applications on a case-by-case basis, considering operational requirements. Where possible QSPP will endeavour to find a mutually agreeable date with the pharmacy.

The accreditation expiry date may also be unilaterally changed by QSPP, provided it does not negatively impact the pharmacy.

Sanction extensions

Where extenuating circumstances exist, a pharmacy may request more time to complete a sanction. Where public safety is not a risk as a result of the sanction, the extension request will be considered against the criteria for *Corrective Action Extensions* (above).

Where sanctions relate to public safety concerns, QSPP will only consider extensions where it is demonstrated this safety risk has been mitigated.

Appealable decisions

Extension request outcomes are appealable decisions, consistent with the QSPP Program Rules and the *Procedural Fairness and Impartiality Policy*.

Related Documentation

Procedural Fairness and Impartiality Policy
Program Rules
QSPP Terms and Conditions
Sanctions Management Policy